

ALL PALACES ARE TEMPORARY PALACES BY ROSEBUD BEN-ONI

Rosebud Ben-Oni is an American Poet. Her work explores identity, change and the interplay between science and art. The poem “All Palaces are Temporary Palaces” reflects on the fleeting nature of human creations. It also talks about the search for permanence in an impermanent world. In the poem, she emphasizes the impermanence of human accomplishments. For this, she uses the image of palaces to symbolize success, ambition and the desire for lasting impact.....These structures are grand and awe-inspiring. However, like everything else, they are subject to time’s inevitable decay. The poem suggests that even the greatest marvels cannot escape the impermanence of existence. Through vivid imagery and a reflective tone, Ben-Oni encourages readers to examine the value they place on material achievements. Palaces are impressive; but ultimately, they are also fleeting. The pursuit of permanence through such creations can lead to disillusionment. Instead, the poem proposes that true meaning lies in intangible experiences, such as relationships, emotions and the memories we create with others. The poem also highlights humanity’s innate desire for stability and permanence. This is often expressed through building monuments or institutions. Yet, it gently reminds us that change is an unavoidable part of life. Clinging to the illusion of permanence may prevent us from embracing the beauty and meaning found in life’s transitory nature. To conclude, this poem is a meditation on the transient nature of human endeavors. It advises readers to shift their focus from chasing lasting material achievements to appreciating the present moment and the connections they share with others. Ben-Oni invites us to find fulfillment in the fleeting yet profound beauty of life’s experiences.

POEM

LINE BY LINE:

My niece calls with questions of asteroid mining

Asteroid mining is the theoretical process of extracting valuable materials from asteroids and other minor planets, particularly near-Earth objects. This concept is gaining interest due to the potential wealth of resources it could provide, although it also raises complex ethical questions.

At six she’s worried & can’t tell me why.

The quote, "At six she's worried & can't tell me why," is from Rosebud Ben-Oni, reflecting her niece's concern about complex topics like asteroid mining, showcasing the innocence yet depth of a child's worries. The line illustrates how children can have anxieties about the world and issues they may not fully understand.

So we talk it out. I hear there is gold, silver, platinum on spent comets.

In the context of Rosebud Ben-Oni's poetry, the mention of "gold, silver, platinum on spent comets" suggests a contemplation of value and the preciousness of experiences or emotions amidst a backdrop of cosmic imagery. The lines evoke a sense of longing or exploration of relationships and commitment, possibly questioning what holds significance in our choices and affections.

Who would say I do on a stony Asteroid?

In a poetic context, the phrase "Who would say I do on a stony asteroid?" by Rosebud Ben-Oni seems to explore themes of connection and commitment in an isolated or distant setting, reflecting on relationships that may feel far apart or challenging. The mention of "gold, silver, platinum" suggests value and transformation amidst a harsh environment, while also possibly commenting on the human experience.

People are already getting married underwater,

The poet likely uses the imagery of people getting married underwater to highlight the contrast between the romantic ideal of marriage and its deeper implications. This juxtaposition suggests that while a wedding may seem significant and celebratory (like an underwater ceremony), it may also be tinged with emptiness or hollowness at its core. This serves to critique societal views on the big day, implying that the true essence of love and connection can sometimes be lost in the spectacle of the event. There is more relevance in marriage than the so-called making of an event does to it. You make event management do so many things to make marriage day memorable. But that is a foolish act because the solemnity of marriage holds much more than what you can show through events.

The very rich driving cars on coral reefs

The phrase "the very rich driving cars on coral reefs" likely symbolizes the excess and carelessness of the wealthy, highlighting their disregard for the environment. It suggests that their luxurious lifestyles are damaging to delicate ecosystems like coral reefs, illustrating a broader critique of how affluence can contribute to environmental degradation.

& if the newest frontiers require technology smaller than an atom

the lines from Latina Jewish poet Ben-Oni about "the newest frontiers require technology smaller than an atom" likely reflect a commentary on the cutting-edge advancements in science and technology, particularly in fields like quantum mechanics and nanotechnology. This imagery

suggests a focus on the profound implications of these advancements for human existence, identity, and understanding of the universe. It may also indicate a blend of cultural and scientific exploration, emphasizing how poetry can engage with contemporary issues in a rapidly evolving world.

(kavitha bhavana prapancha nigoodathakal palathum velipeduththi tharum)

There's the pentaquark which is almost all quark save for one antiquark

The poetess likely uses "pentaquark" metaphorically to illustrate a complex relationship or situation that comprises various elements (the four quarks) balanced by an oppositional component (the antiquark). In physics, a pentaquark is a composite particle made up of four quarks and one antiquark, representing a unique state that doesn't occur naturally but is a fascinating example of particle behavior. This might symbolize the idea of coexistence between opposing forces or ideas.

(Prakruthiyude avasthakal palapozhum nigoodam aanu. Saamaanya budhiyil ava visheshippikkano

Vivarikkano kazhiyilla. Oru kaviyude bhavana pole bhavanaatmakamaayi athine kaanuvaan naam padikkanam.)

& if not for the antiquark , would anything, any - Thing at all, be?

The poetess seems to be exploring the fundamental nature of existence, suggesting that the presence of the antiquark, a crucial element in particle physics, is essential for anything to exist at all. This conveys a philosophical inquiry into the nature of reality and existence, hinting at the interdependence of all things in the universe.

What's next is never enough?

"What's next is never enough" reflects a mindset influenced by the "toxic achievement culture," where the pursuit of constantly achieving more leaves individuals feeling unsatisfied and uneasy. This phenomenon is prevalent in today's fast-paced world, often pushing people to chase after more without finding contentment. It highlights the psychological aspect of always wanting more, despite having achieved significant milestones.

Salim kumar parayunna pole thirupathi (thripathi - satisfaction) avilla mone thirupathi avilla

All left to chance shrinking

My dear, dear girl

Calling on this overcast day in the spring, where sky is one long cover of impassivity.

Ee aakasam ingane anangathe, meghangal neengathe, ninnal enthinu kollaam?

Impassivity = Impassivity refers to a state of being without any emotional response or expression; it is characterized by a lack of feelings or reactions, making one appear emotionless or apathetic.

Why are we here?

She 's asking for the first time,

& I hear the anxiety of one who's stumbled upon a burning temple in the fields.

He/she had some bad experiences. "Temple in the Fields" by Rosebud Ben-Oni is a poem that explores themes of connection, memory, and introspection. It reflects on a moment of pause and contemplation, using imagery of a temple and a winding staircase in Woodside, Queens, to evoke feelings of nostalgia and wonder. The poem captures the anxiety and curiosity of discovering something profound in a seemingly ordinary setting.

We listen to each other Breathe.

The poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" by ben Oni is heartfelt and reflects themes of connection and memory, particularly through the perspective of the speaker's interactions with their niece. The line "We listen to each other Breathe" emphasizes the importance of presence and shared experiences.

I miss my train, linger on a winding staircase In Woodside Queens.

In the poem by Ben Oni, the line "I miss my train, linger on a winding staircase in Woodside Queens" suggests a sense of missed opportunity or regret, reflecting on a moment of pause in a specific place that carries personal significance. The imagery of the winding staircase can symbolize the complexities of life and decisions, while Woodside Queens might represent a familiar, yet transitional space. This line conveys a deep emotional experience, emphasizing moments of reflection amidst the hustle of daily life.

I remember the day I discovered

This small stretch of exposed track subverting the sky & knew

I'd come home.

The phrase suggests a moment of profound awareness and connection with a place, conveying feelings of belonging and familiarity. The "small stretch of exposed track" may symbolize a path or journey in life, while "subverting the sky" could imply a feeling of defiance or transcendence. In essence, she feels as though she has returned to her roots or a significant part of her identity.

One more day & I will tell her this,
One more day for life on asteroids without fences or fracking
& dreams know no deep inelastic scattering.

In these lines, the poetess Ben Oni reflects on anticipation and the freedom found in dreams. The mention of "life on asteroids without fences or fracking" symbolizes a desire for unbounded existence, free from societal constraints and environmental degradation. The phrase "dreams know no deep inelastic scattering" suggests that her dreams are limitless and untouched by the complexities and challenges of reality, where "deep inelastic scattering" refers to a scientific concept that may signify profound, unpredictable disruption. This ultimately captures a longing for a more liberated life and the hope of revealing true feelings the next day. Fracking is the process of injecting liquid at high pressure into subterranean rocks. This line envisions a space free of human exploitation, a realm untouched by the destructive forces of resource extraction and the constraints of ownership. It represents a fleeting hope for an unblemished existence—an escape from Earth's imperfections. However, the phrase "*one more day*" underscores the ephemeral nature of this imagined freedom, reinforcing the idea that even utopias are temporary.

Drawing from physics, *deep inelastic scattering* refers to the process by which particles collide and reveal internal structures. The line suggests that dreams exist beyond such fragmentation or dissection—they are intangible, unified, and limitless. This contrast between the scientific and the abstract highlights the resilience of human imagination even in the face of disintegration or scrutiny.

Let it be where silence is never summoned, where rays collide in charm & strange.

In the passage "where silence is never summoned, where rays collide in charm & strange," the phrase "Ben Oni" likely refers to a deeper emotional or existential concept. "Ben Oni," directly translated from Hebrew, means "son of my sorrow" or "son of my pain." This could imply a place or state where sorrow is acknowledged and intertwined with beauty and complexity, rather than being silenced or ignored. The mention of "rays" suggests moments of light or joy that collide with the heavier themes of sorrow, highlighting a juxtaposition of feelings and experiences. The plea for a place where silence is not imposed suggests a world of unrestrained expression and vitality. Silence here could symbolize oppression, stagnation, or the absence of connection. The speaker yearns for a realm where vibrancy and interaction flourish without inhibition. This line directly references quantum mechanics, where "charm" and "strange" are

types of quarks, fundamental particles. The imagery of "rays colliding" evokes dynamic interactions at the subatomic level, symbolizing the profound beauty and energy of existence. The interplay of "charm" and "strange" also implies a balance between the delightful and the uncanny—both essential elements of life and the cosmos.

EXERCISES:

Answer the following questions in two or three sentences:

1. Identify the speaker of the poem?

Ans: The speaker of the poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" is Rosebud Ben-Oni.

2. Outline the relationship between childhood curiosity and adult knowledge as mentioned in the poem?

Ans: In the poem "All palaces are temporary palaces," childhood curiosity is portrayed as a vital spark that fosters growth into adult knowledge. The poet reflects on how a child's innocent inquiries and concerns—like those of a niece worried about asteroid mining—highlight a sense of wonder and pursuit of understanding that, when nurtured, evolves into deeper knowledge and perspectives in adulthood. This relationship underscores the idea that the questions we grapple with as children can shape our intellectual and emotional frameworks as adults.

3. State the central theme of the poem?

Ans: The central theme of the poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" revolves around the impermanence of power, possession, and material wealth. It reflects on how even the grandest constructions and displays of wealth are ultimately fleeting, highlighting issues related to ownership and the transient nature of human achievements.

4. Sketch the use of imagery to convey the meaning?

Ans: Imagery in Rosebud Ben Oni's poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" serves to evoke a sense of impermanence and the fragility of human constructs and achievements. The poem likely utilizes vivid descriptions of both opulence (great wealth and luxuriousness) and decay, encapsulating the idea that even the grandest aspects of life are ultimately transient. For instance, images of "the very rich driving cars on coral reefs" juxtapose wealth with vulnerability, hinting at environmental concerns and the fleeting

nature of luxury. Such imagery reinforces the overarching theme that material possessions and status are temporary, fostering reflection on what truly endures.

5. Comment on the tone of the poem?

Ans: The tone of the poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" can be described as melancholic and reflective. The phrase emphasizes the transient nature of wealth and status, suggesting that grand structures or achievements are ultimately fleeting. This can evoke a sense of sadness or resignation regarding the impermanence of material success and the human condition. The connection to European migration hints at deeper societal issues, adding layers of poignancy to the message.

Answer the following questions in a paragraph:

6. Enumerate (mention one by one) how the poem blends scientific concepts with childhood wonder?

Ans: The poem "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" skillfully combines scientific concepts with childhood wonder by presenting the transient nature of human creations through a lens of imagination and curiosity. It reflects on the impermanence of structures (a scientific idea related to entropy (in physics a thermodynamic quantity representing the unavailability of a system's thermal energy for conversion into mechanical work, often interpreted as the degree of disorder or randomness in the system) and decay) while invoking the playful and boundless creativity characteristic of childhood. This duality invites readers to explore the interplay between the factual world of science and the limitless possibilities of a child's mind, where each moment can be filled with awe and exploration. That mind has to be borne by a science curio so that he/she can go to any possibilities of invention. The central theme revolves around the idea that all creations, no matter how grand, are ultimately temporary. This reflects the natural cycle of life and decay. The poem captures the innocence and imagination of childhood, celebrating the ability to see beauty and magic in everyday life. Poetry often weaves in various scientific concepts that reflect the wonders of the natural world, human experience, and existential themes.

7. Elaborate on the role of the natural world and its contribution to the theme of transience?

Ans: In Rosebud Ben-Oni's poem "All Palaces are Temporary Palaces," the natural world serves as a poignant reminder of the transience of human constructs and emotions. The imagery of environmental changes, such as coral reefs, juxtaposes the fleeting nature of human achievements, like opulent palaces, emphasizing that all earthly creations are ultimately impermanent. Through this connection, Ben-Oni reflects on the ephemeral quality of life, reinforcing the notion that despite our wealth or status, none can escape the natural decay and transformation that characterizes existence. That is why Bhagavad Geetha says not to run after the worldly creations as they are all the so called MAYA.

Transience in the poetry confronts the inevitability of death and change thus advocating the readers to consider their own lives and its fleeting nature. Transience can enhance the appreciation of beauty, highlighting the idea that moments are precious precisely because they are temporary. Transience often evokes deep emotions, connecting the reader to universal human experiences of loss, change, and the passing of time.

8. Significance of “All Palaces are Temporary Palaces” ?

Ans: The phrase “All Palaces are Temporary Palaces” suggests that grand structures or states of existence, often associated with power or success, are ultimately fleeting. It reflects on the transient nature of human achievements, possibly inspired by the ideas of cultural critique and temporality found in the works of artists and philosophers like Guy Debord and Philip Larkin. This concept underlines the impermanence of life and material success, hinting at a deeper philosophical reflection on the nature of existence and human experience.

9. Assess the role of imagination and wonder in the poem?

Ans: Imagination and wonder play crucial roles in the poem "All Palaces are Temporary Palaces," as they evoke a sense of reflection on impermanence and the transient nature of human achievements. The poem uses vivid imagery and metaphor to illustrate the idea that even the grandest structures, like palaces, are not immune to decay and time. This evokes a sense of wonder about the beauty of these creations while simultaneously acknowledging the inevitable reality of their impermanence. The interplay between imagination and the acceptance of mortality invites the reader to contemplate the deeper significance of life and legacy, leading to a profound emotional experience.

10. Comment on the last four lines of the poem and how it contributes to the overall meaning of the poem?

Ans: The last four lines of Rosebud Ben-Oni’s “*All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces*” reflect a synthesis of scientific imagery, poetic imagination, and existential longing, adding layers of meaning to the poem’s exploration of impermanence and human aspiration.

1. **“One more day for life on asteroids without fences or fracking”:**

This line envisions a space free of human exploitation, a realm untouched by the destructive forces of resource extraction and the constraints of ownership. It represents a fleeting hope for an unblemished existence—an escape from Earth’s imperfections. However, the phrase “one more day” underscores the ephemeral

nature of this imagined freedom, reinforcing the idea that even utopias are temporary.

2. **"& dreams know no deep inelastic scattering":**

Drawing from physics, *deep inelastic scattering* refers to the process by which particles collide and reveal internal structures. The line suggests that dreams exist beyond such fragmentation or dissection—they are intangible, unified, and limitless. This contrast between the scientific and the abstract highlights the resilience of human imagination even in the face of disintegration or scrutiny.

3. **"Let it be where silence is never summoned":**

The plea for a place where silence is not imposed suggests a world of unrestrained expression and vitality. Silence here could symbolize oppression, stagnation, or the absence of connection. The speaker yearns for a realm where vibrancy and interaction flourish without inhibition.

4. **"Where rays collide in charm & strange":**

This line directly references quantum mechanics, where "charm" and "strange" are types of quarks, fundamental particles. The imagery of "rays colliding" evokes dynamic interactions at the subatomic level, symbolizing the profound beauty and energy of existence. The interplay of "charm" and "strange" also implies a balance between the delightful and the uncanny—both essential elements of life and the cosmos.

ESSAY QUESTIONS:

11. Ben-Oni blends scientific concepts with poetic language to create a sense of awe. Elucidate?

Ans: Ben-Oni blends scientific concepts with poetic language in "All Palaces Are Temporary Palaces" to evoke a profound sense of wonder and introspection. By weaving elements of science—potentially referencing themes like impermanence, the cosmos, or human existence—with rich imagery and lyrical phrasing, she highlights the fragility of our achievements and structures. This fusion invites readers to reflect on the transient nature of life, akin to a temporary palace, fostering a feeling of awe regarding both the vastness of the universe and our place within it.

Ben-Oni skillfully intertwines scientific concepts with evocative language to evoke a profound sense of wonder. This fusion allows readers to explore complex ideas while engaging emotionally and intellectually. By employing poetic language, Ben-Oni transforms scientific phenomena into relatable experiences, instilling hope and a sense of connection to the universe. Such an approach celebrates both knowledge and imagination, challenging traditional boundaries and highlighting the beauty found in the intersection of science and art.

The poem uses vivid imagery and metaphors to illustrate complex scientific concepts, making them more accessible and relatable. Scientific themes often evoke feelings of wonder, awe, or even existential contemplation. Poetry captures these emotional responses, allowing readers to experience the beauty and mystery of scientific phenomena. The structured form of poetry, including its rhythm and sound patterns, can reflect the order found in scientific principles, such as patterns in nature or the laws of physics. They delve into the ethical and philosophical implications of scientific advancements, encouraging readers to ponder the human condition in relation to scientific progress.

The poem often emphasizes the interconnectedness of all things, a theme prominent in both science and literature. This perspective can foster a deeper appreciation of the universe and our place within it. By weaving together these elements, poetry serves as a unique medium to explore and celebrate the wonders of science, bridging the gap between the analytical and the emotional.

12. Analyze how Ben-Oni explores tension between the desire for permanence and the reality of transience?

Ans: In her poem "All Palaces are temporary palaces," Ben-Oni explores the tension between the desire for permanence and the reality of transience by juxtaposing grand, enduring imagery with the inevitable decay and impermanence of life. The poem reflects on human experiences and emotions that seek stability and lasting significance, yet are constantly challenged by the fleeting nature of existence. This duality highlights the struggle to find meaning in a world where everything is subject to change, emphasizing that while we may build metaphorical palaces in our lives, they remain temporary structures against the backdrop of time and mortality.

The imagery of palaces evokes grandeur, stability, and a sense of aspiration. It represents our desires for permanence and achievement, symbolizing the emotional and physical sanctuaries we create in our lives. By contrasting these palatial images with references to decay, destruction, or the passage of time, Ben-Oni highlights the fleeting nature of such constructs. This juxtaposition emphasizes that even the most beautiful and seemingly permanent aspects of life are vulnerable. Ben-Oni uses vivid imagery of light, decay, and nature to reflect emotions like hope, nostalgia, and sorrow. By painting pictures with words, she engages readers' senses and evokes feelings that resonate with their own experiences of transience. The palaces symbolize not just physical places but also

emotional states and aspirations. Other images, such as falling leaves or crumbling walls, symbolize the inevitable decline that accompanies life's beauty.

Ben-Oni often integrates natural imagery to illustrate the cycles of life, linking human experiences to the natural world. This reinforces the idea that everything, including human constructs, is susceptible to the forces of time and change. References to time—day and night, seasons changing—serve to remind readers of the temporality of all things, driving home the contrast between human desire for permanence and the reality of transience. Through these layers of imagery, Ben-Oni effectively communicates the struggle between our aspirations for lasting significance and the inevitability of change. Her imagery serves not only to paint a vivid picture but also to provoke reflection on our own lives and the palaces we construct, reminding us to cherish the moments that are, however fleeting.

